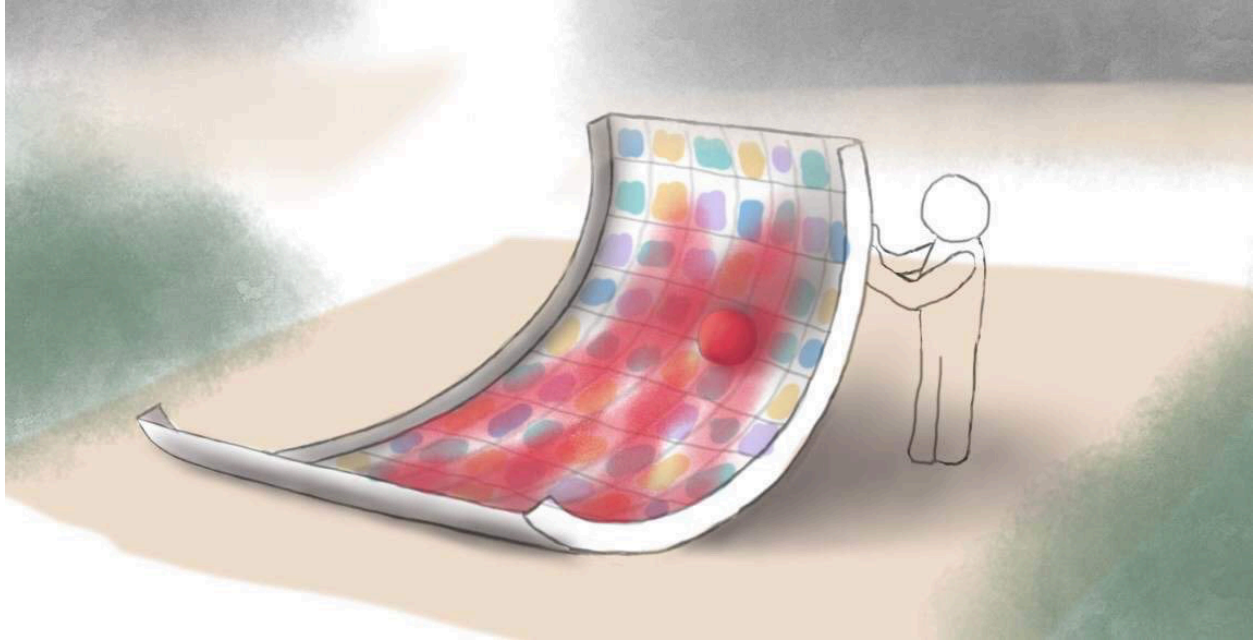




Designing an Interactive Installation for Seattle Design Festival

An experiential design project exploring online identity, offline presence, and personal balance.

Seattle Design Festival is a citywide design event that brings together designers, community members, civic leaders, and organizations to explore how design can shape better experiences and communities.

For the 2019 festival, our team created a physical installation in response to the theme: **Balance.**

We were interested in the balance between people's online and offline lives - how much time we spend in each space, how we present ourselves differently, and how digital habits can shape our sense of identity. Our goal was to create an installation that invited people to physically interact with the theme rather than simply read about it.

Project Snapshot

Project / Client: Seattle Design Festival interactive installation

Timeline: June 2019 – August 2019

Role: Project Manager, Designer, Builder

Team / Stakeholders: 4 designers/builders, Seattle Design Festival visitors

Problem Space: Creating a physical installation in response to the festival theme “Balance,” focused on online identity, offline presence, and personal reflection

Methods: Individual brainstorming, group ideation, concept development, experiential design, physical prototyping, fabrication

Tools: Sketching, woodworking tools, spray paint, physical fabrication materials

Outputs: Installation concept, ideation sketches, fabricated physical installation, public festival experience

Outcome / Impact: Built an interactive installation that invited festival visitors to reflect on the balance between online and offline presence through physical engagement

Focus Areas: Experiential design, physical interaction, installation design, project management, visual communication, public engagement

The Challenge

The Seattle Design Festival theme asked participants to explore the idea of balance.

Our team interpreted this through the lens of modern identity: the balance between who we are online, who we are offline, and how much time and energy we give to each version of ourselves.

We wanted visitors to reflect on questions like:

How much time do I spend online versus offline?

How do I present myself differently in digital and physical spaces?

Does my online presence reflect my authentic self?

What would a healthier balance look like?

Rather than designing a text-heavy installation, we wanted to create something physical, visual, and participatory - something people could understand by moving through it, touching it, and reacting to it.

My Role

I served as the project manager, designer, and builder for the installation.

My role included helping the team stay organized, contributing to early concept development, supporting the physical design direction, coordinating build tasks, and helping fabricate the final installation.

Because this was a physical project with a limited budget and timeline, project management and execution were just as important as the concept itself. We needed to make something that was meaningful, engaging, durable, transportable, and realistic to build with the resources we had.

Design Goal

Our goal was to create a physical installation that encouraged visitors to reconsider the balance between their online and offline presence.

We wanted the experience to feel:

Interactive rather than passive

Visual rather than text-heavy

Approachable for a public festival environment

Reflective without feeling too serious or instructional

Simple enough to understand quickly

Open-ended enough to invite conversation

The installation needed to work for people who might only stop for a few seconds, while still offering more meaning for those who wanted to engage more deeply.

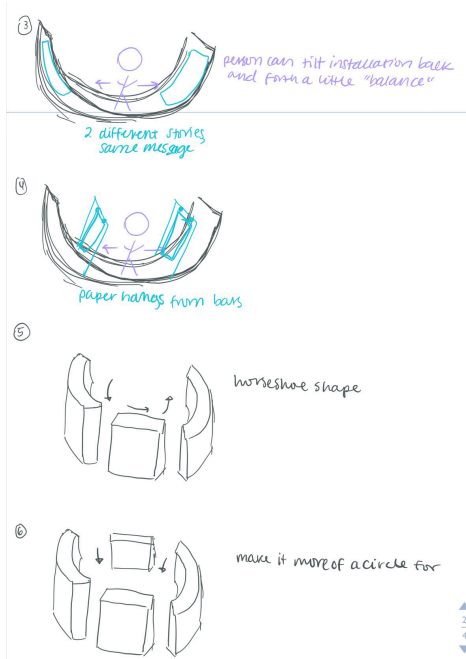
Ideation

We began by individually brainstorming different installation concepts, then came together to discuss which ideas best supported the festival theme and the visitor experience we wanted to create.

During ideation, we explored how people might physically move through or interact with the installation. We were especially drawn to concepts that required visitors to do something with their bodies - not just stand in front of a display and read.

Two of my early sketches helped inspire the final direction. We liked the idea of using physical movement as part of the message because it made the theme of balance more tangible.

We intentionally decided not to include a long timeline, explanation, or text-heavy narrative. In a festival setting, we believed visuals and interaction would be more memorable than a written explanation. We wanted visitors to guide their own experience: engage first, then ask as many or as few questions as they wanted.



Caption: Early sketches explored how physical movement and visual contrast could help visitors reflect on online and offline balance.

Concept Direction

Our final concept used physical interaction to represent the tension between online and offline presence.

Rather than telling people what to think, the installation invited them to engage with the idea of balance through movement, space, and visual metaphor. This helped make the concept more accessible in a public environment where visitors had different levels of time, interest, and design knowledge.

The experience was designed to be simple at first glance, but meaningful once people paused to consider what it represented.

Design Principles

As we moved from concept to build, we used a few principles to guide our decisions.

Make the interaction intuitive.

Visitors should be able to understand how to engage without needing a long explanation.

Let the visual design carry the message.

Because the installation was part of a busy public festival, the idea needed to communicate quickly through form, movement, and contrast.

Encourage reflection, not instruction.

We wanted the installation to invite people to think about their own habits and identity, not tell them there was one “correct” way to balance online and offline life.

Build within real constraints.

The final installation needed to be achievable with our budget, tools, materials, timeline, and team capacity.

Building the Installation

Over two months, our team turned the concept into a physical installation.

Because we had a limited budget and resources, practicality mattered. We needed to make design decisions that were visually effective, structurally realistic, and possible for us to build ourselves.

The fabrication process included:

Measuring and cutting wood pieces

Sanding materials

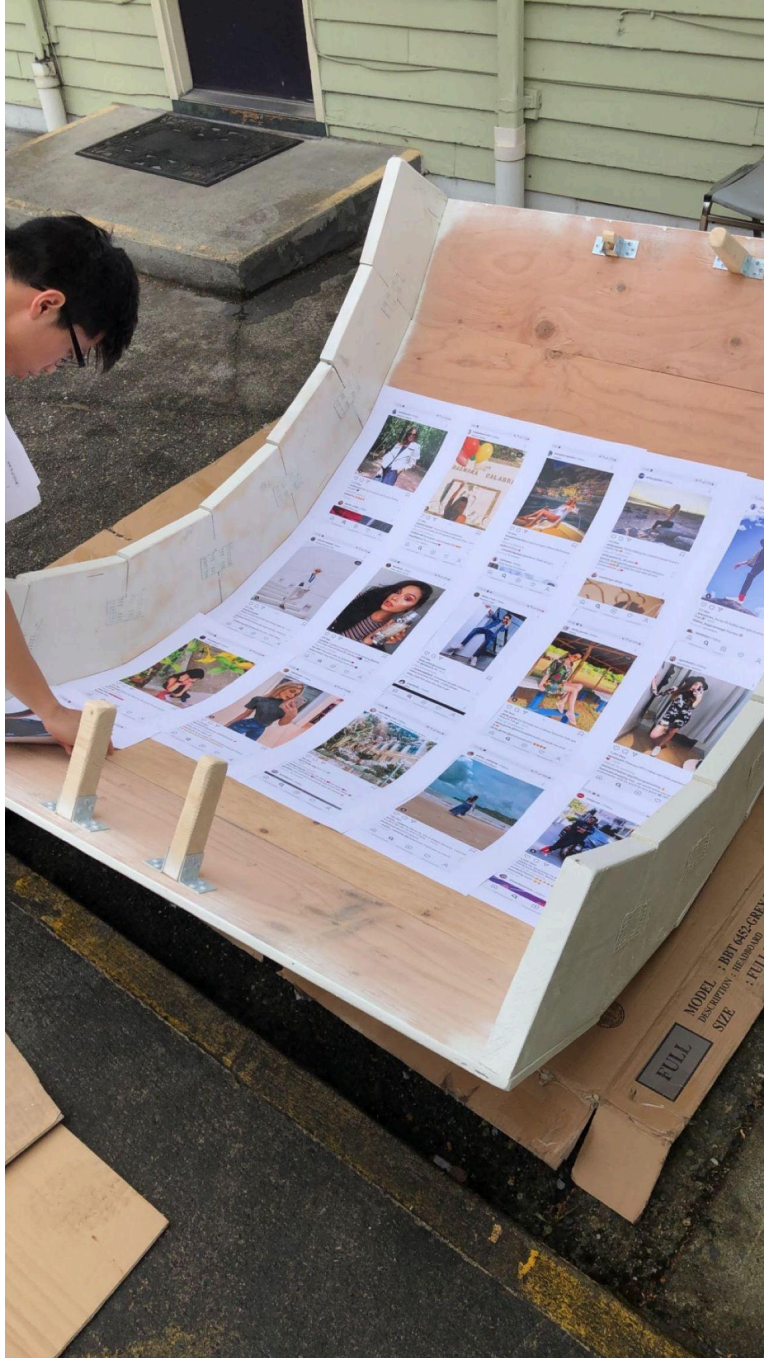
Spray painting components

Assembling the structure

Nailing pieces together

Transporting and preparing the installation for the festival

This was one of my first experiences building a physical design at this scale. It pushed me to think beyond screens and consider how materials, space, construction, and durability shape the user experience.



Caption: *With limited budget and materials, we fabricated the installation by hand, from cutting and sanding wood to painting and assembly.*

Collaboration

Our team brought together different backgrounds across architecture, Human-Centered Design & Engineering, and marketing.

That mix made the work stronger. Some teammates thought more spatially, others thought more about audience and messaging, and others focused on interaction and usability. Because the project required both concept development and physical execution, we had to listen carefully, communicate clearly, and make decisions efficiently.

As project manager, I helped the team stay aligned on the goal while making sure we continued moving toward a finished installation.

Final Installation

The final installation invited Seattle Design Festival visitors to physically engage with the theme of balance and reflect on how they divide time, attention, and identity between online and offline spaces.

Instead of relying on a detailed explanation, the installation used interaction and visual design to create a more open-ended experience. Visitors could engage quickly or spend more time asking questions and discussing the concept with our team.

The final result was a public-facing design experience that translated an abstract theme into something tangible, participatory, and approachable.





Caption: *The final installation used physical interaction to invite reflection on online identity, offline presence, and personal balance.*

Why This Project Mattered

This project taught me that experience design is not limited to digital products.

A physical installation still requires many of the same skills I use in UX: understanding an audience, designing for context, simplifying a complex idea, creating an intuitive interaction, and considering how people will feel as they move through an experience.

It also helped me understand the importance of constraints. With limited time, budget, and tools, our team had to make practical decisions without losing the core concept.

Reflection

Looking back, this project was an early lesson in experiential design, collaboration, and bringing an idea into the physical world.

I learned that frequent communication is especially important when a project moves from concept to fabrication. Because we were building something by hand, small misalignments could affect the final product, timeline, or construction process.

I also learned that individual brainstorming can make group ideation stronger. Giving each person time to explore ideas independently helped us bring more creative concepts to the table. Then, group discussion helped us converge around a shared direction and stay aligned on the experience we wanted to create.

Most importantly, this project expanded how I thought about design. It showed me that a user experience can be a screen, a service, a space, an object, or a moment of reflection in a public festival.

What I'd Do Differently Today

If I were approaching this project now, I would spend more time observing how visitors interacted with the installation during the festival.

I would want to better understand:

Whether visitors understood the concept without explanation

Which parts of the installation invited the most interaction

Whether the physical movement actually helped people reflect on the theme

How long people engaged with the installation

What questions or conversations the experience prompted

I would also consider adding a lightweight feedback mechanism, such as a prompt wall, quick response card, or simple interactive vote, to better capture how people interpreted the installation.

Even with those limitations, this project gave me valuable experience designing for physical interaction, public engagement, and experiential storytelling.

Short Version for the Project Card

Designing an Interactive Installation for Seattle Design Festival

Project managed, designed, and built a physical installation for Seattle Design Festival's "Balance" theme. The installation invited visitors to reflect on their online and offline presence through a visual, participatory experience built with limited budget, materials, and time.

Tags

Experiential Design · Physical Interaction · Installation Design · Project Management · Design Thinking · Visual Communication · Fabrication · Public Engagement · Human-Centered Design · Concept Development